WHERE THE ROAD BEGINS

The biggest game-changer in the 'war' has been the introduction of tech, including call monitoring, drones and UAVs, especially in intelligence. Security camps in vulnerable areas, though, continue to be the fulcrum of the anti-Maoist strategy. The presence of a camp increases the reach of the security forces as they serve as launchpads for operations. Camps are also centres for public outreach, providing medical facilities and sundry help to locals. Most importantly, the presence of a camp and a road that leads to it keeps Maoists away from the area, perhaps also why they are opposed to their construction. There are close to 160 security camps in Bastar now—30 came up this year alone—housing both state police personnel and CAPFs (central armed police forces).

The focus now is on the two key 'security vacuum areas'—regions where, to put it simply, the writ of the state does not run. Abujhmaad—literally, the unknown forest—is the prize target here. Spread over 4,000 sq. km, of which around 60 per cent lies in Narayanpur district, 15 per cent in Bijapur, 10 per cent in Kanker and 5 per cent in Gadchiroli in Maharashtra, it exemplifies what the Maoists call 'liberated zones'. So how successful have the forces been in penetrating this area? "We now have nine camps inside Abujhmaad— there were none earlier," says IG Bastar, Sundarraj Pattilingam, which is answer enough. A new camp, Garpa in Narayanpur, secured through a western thrust from the district HQ, has secured Karushnar and Sonpur *(see map)*. Another camp at Irrakbatti, gained through a southwestern thrust via Kokometa, and one at Mohandi through a southern thrust has secured Farasgaon, Chote Dongar and Orchha.

The other hitherto impregnable rebel fortress was on the Sukma-Bijapur border. This is the forested area controlled by Battalion No. 1 of the PLGA (People's Liberation Guerrilla Army). Neutralising this battalion headed by Madvi Hidma, one of the fighters on the 'most wanted' list, is top priority. Hidma is the only Bastar local to have risen this high in the Maoist hierarchy, all the other top leaders being either Telugu, Bengali or from Jharkhand.

BLEEDING FROM THE SIDES

Estimates vary but Battalion No. 1 is said to be down to 300 fighters, trimmed from the 600-plus it had earlier. The formation is said to have the best weaponry and the most committed fighters. As part of the strategy to take them on, the forces have dominated the area north of it, creating a secure area around Avapalli, Tarrem, Basaguda and Usoor. A southward push is now possible from these areas.

What seems to be helping the forces is also a perceptible weakening of the Maoist movement materially. The bulk of weapons available with them now are muzzle loader guns or crude single shot rifles, evidence of which comes from the seizures this year—of the 263 weapons recovered after encounters, the bulk were countrymade pistols, crude 12 bore guns or muzzle loaders. The most common field weapon is a crude barrel grenade launcher, made in-house and which fires a projectile.

THE NEW STRATEGIES

- **The game-changer has been tech, including call monitoring, drones and UAVs, in intel gathering**
- **Overwhelm the Maoists with numbers; at least 1,000 personnel involved in every operation**
- **Units made of tribal youth, ex-Salwa Judum and ex-Maoists–like DRG, Bastar Fighters and District Strike Force–now the 'tip of the spear'**
- **Security camps–160 now in Bastar–and roads in vulnerable areas still crucial to anti-Maoist playbook**

STEPPING UP THE PRESSURE

The security forces, which now include at least three units made up of local recruits, besides the CAPF and the local police, have taken the fight to the Maoists in 2024

MAOIST RUN-INS IN BASTAR OVER THE YEARS



Of the sophisticated AKs, INSAS and SLRs, police sources say many of these are old and have maintenance issues—a large number have also been recovered. Ammunition, too, has become a problem as the state has closed the gaps on pilfered prohibited bore (Pb) cartridges from munition factories. Intelligence available suggests that the shortage of ammunition has compelled Maoists to even reduce training rounds for fresh recruits. Cash flows through levies on tendu patta collection, estimated at around Rs 150 crore every year, have also choked up, as have those imposed on civil contractors of roads or bridges.

So is the end near for the Maoist movement in Chhattisgarh? Sundarraj prefers a diplomatic reply. "From the security point of view, our objective is to dismantle the leadership and ensure no fresh Maoist cases are reported. In other words, we want the Maoist